



The Garamut "The message sender"

Ps Barry Reflections from 'The WORD'! **For PRAYER, PROCLAMATION & PERSONAL PROGRESS**

Bethel Global Missions
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Our focus: WHEN GOD RAN

Luke 15:18-32 NIV

18 I will set out and go back to my father and say to him: Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you.

19 I am no longer worthy to be called your son; make me like one of your hired men.'

*20 So he got up and went to his father. "But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; **he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him.***

21 "The son said to him, 'Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you. I am no longer worthy to be called your son.'

22 "But the father said to his servants, 'Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet.

23 Bring the fattened calf and kill it. Let's have a feast and celebrate.

*24 For this son of mine was **DEAD** and is **ALIVE** again; he was **LOST** and is **FOUND**.' So they began to celebrate.*

*32 **But we had to celebrate and be glad, because this brother of yours was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found.**" NIV*



NOW THERE WERE OTHER PEOPLE WHO RAN TO SEE JESUS LIKE:

- **ZACCHAEUS** - Luke 19:4 and **MARY RAN** to see the empty tomb - John 20:1-5 - **SIMON PETER and OTHERS** also **RAN** to the empty tomb - John 20:2,3,4 - **THE DEMON POSSESSED (Legion)** **RAN** to worship Jesus - Mark 5:6 - **PHILIP RAN** to the chariot of the Ethiopian man - Acts 8:30

► **BUT WHEN GOD RAN – IT ECLIPSED THEM ALL.**

APPLICATION

I am using the story recorded in Luke 15 of a prodigal son returning back to his earthly father after a long time away - **AS AN ANALOGY OR PICTURE** of a sinner returning back to our heavenly father and the manner in which the father responded to the son.

THE FATHER'S EAGERNESS

- His eagerness – his love – his compassion **CANCELLED OUT, SET ASIDE, OVERRULED** all other factors in the father's feelings.

EXAMPLE OF WHAT THE FATHER HAD TO SET ASIDE

- His disappointment at the attitude and manner in which his son in leaving home.
- His sadness that he turned his back on the father and that he may never see his son again.
- The father's hope that his son might make good with the inheritance and become a person of significance (a businessman) etc.
- Then the father would have been aware to some extent of the attitude of the older brother towards his brother who had left home.
- The disappointment and hurt that Father faced that his son caused him. Acting totally the opposite to the good things that his father might have planned for him.

A STUMBLING BLOCK FOR CHRISTIANS

- Many of these things that the father faced are stumbling blocks to many believers – maybe even you are struggling to set aside – to cancel out one or more of those things.
- Christians today continue to carry past hurts and disappointments for months and even years.
- Remaining ungracious, unforgiving and hanging on to past events. Where believers or friends who have messed up and have disappointed us and we can get beyond the questions of ‘why did they act like that?’
They were our leaders and mentors, and they completely dropped out from Christian living.

► WHILE THE SON WAS A LONG WAY OFF (GREAT DISTANCE), THE FATHER SAW THE SON- HE RAN TO HIM.

And while he was still a long distance away, his father saw him coming, and was filled with loving pity and ran and embraced him and kissed him TLB

But while he was still some distance off, his father saw him and his heart went out to him, and he ran and fell on his neck and kissed him. PHILLIPS

► BUT REGARDLESS OF THESE HURDLES THE FATHER RAN TOWARDS HIS RETURNING SON

Important to note – NO RECORD

- There is no record of the father being aware of the reckless and wasteful lifestyle of his son and his decline to poverty and destitution.
- No record that the father knew of the son’s change of attitude, of his sorrow for sin and offending heaven and his earthly father his sorrowful and repentant heart.
- BUT REGARDLESS
- In spite of the ignorance of those things THE FATHER RAN TOWARDS HIS SON WITH A GENUINE HEART OF ACCEPTANCE OVERWHELMING JOY.
- WHAT MADE HIM DO THAT?
- BECAUSE HE LOVES regardless of the state or responsiveness of man.

AN IMPORTANT NOTE - In this case the father acted this way BEFORE he was aware of the son’s repentance, humility and acknowledgement of sin.

APPLICATION

► THIS IS ALSO AN EXAMPLE THAT CHARACTERIZES OUR HEAVENLY FATHER’S LOVE FOR MAN; HE LOVES REGARDLESS OF MAN’S CONDITION OR RESPONSIVENESS.

HE LOVED WITHOUT REQUIRING A HUMAN REASON FOR DOING SO.

This earthly father showed JOY with NO RECRIMINATION towards his returning son.

APPLICATION

► OUR HEAVENLY FATHER LOVES AND DOESN’T REQUIRE A REASON OUTSIDE OF HIMSELF – he loves simply because he is love.

NO RECRIMINATION - NO RETALIATION

Another example of this is in the attitude of Christ towards Simon Peter, who messed up (later sorry & wept bitterly) when they met on the seashore with fire and fish – there was no rebuke from Jesus, no retaliatory blame, no “Peter you hurt and disappointed me” and no reference to his past failure: JUST AN APPEAL “do you love me” John 21:15,16,17.

APPLICATION

THIS IS THE SAME ATTITUDE OF OUR HEAVENLY FATHER TOWARDS ALL THOSE WHO HAVE MESSED UP BUT SORRY FOR THEIR SINS – THERE WAS NO RETALIATORY ACCUSATION – BUT JUST AN APPEAL “IF YOU LOVE ME – FOLLOW ME”

In this same chapter of Luke 15 we have the LOST SON, the LOST SHEEP Luke 15:7 and the LOST COIN Luke 15:10 and each refers to THE exhilarating JOY OF FINDING WHAT HAD BEEN LOST there is joy in the presence of the angels of God when one sinner repents.”

- IT AMAZES ME THAT SUCH A GOD WOULD RUN TOWARDS ME TO EMBRACE ME – ACCEPT ME – SHOW SUCH ENDEARMENT (KISSES) TOWARDS ME.
- I’M SO GLAD THAT I CAN SAY “THANK YOU GOD THAT YOU RAN”